

NBF-TBT-004 - Ladders and General H&S

09/10/2026

Introduction

Today's talk is about ladders and general health and safety. We have been reminded on site that ladders are being used the wrong way. A ladder is only for short, light work and getting from one level to another. Most ladder falls happen on quick jobs where someone took a shortcut, and a fall from two metres can end your career.

Improper use of ladders - what we must not do

- Do not climb or stand on a ladder that is untagged, damaged, wet, muddy or not in date.
- Do not overreach. Keep your belt buckle between the stiles and move the ladder instead.
- Do not stand on the top three rungs, or on the top step of a step ladder.
- Do not use a ladder for work that needs both hands, heavy tools or heavy materials. Use a podium, tower or MEWP.
- Do not carry loads up a ladder. Use a rope, a hoist or a second man.
- Do not use a ladder as a work platform for long jobs. More than about 30 minutes in one position needs proper access.
- Do not set a ladder on bricks, pallets, boards or soft or sloping ground.
- Do not use a ladder that is too short. A leaning ladder must stand 1m above the landing, at a 1 in 4 angle, and be tied off.
- Do not use a ladder where there is a vehicle, door, crane lift or plant moving nearby without a barrier or a person to guard it.
- Do not climb up the formwork, props or stacked material instead of using proper access. Never.

Before you use a ladder

- Check it has an in-date inspection tag. No tag, no use.
- Check the stiles, rungs, feet and locking bars for damage. Report and tag out any damaged ladder straight away.
- Check the feet are clean and the ground is firm and level.
- Ladders must be secured at the top, or footed by a second person if they cannot be tied.
- Keep three points of contact at all times, two feet and a hand.

General H&S on site

- Wear your PPE all the time: hard hat, hi-vis, safety boots, Level 3 cut gloves and safety glasses.
- Check edge protection, covers and handrails before working near an edge. If they are missing, stop and report it.
- Keep walkways, stairs and working areas clear. Remove or bend over nails in stripped timber.
- Keep tools and materials secure so nothing can fall, and keep clear of crane loads.
- Know where the first-aid kit, fire points and muster point are.
- Report every injury, near miss and unsafe condition on the day.

Questions and discussion

- Have you seen a ladder used the wrong way on this job? What should have been used?
- Are the ladders on site tagged and in date?
- Is there a job this week that needs a podium, tower or MEWP instead of a ladder?
- Is there anything unsafe on site right now that we need to fix?

Stopping unsafe work

- Anyone can stop a job they believe is unsafe. Nobody gets in trouble for it.
- Tell your supervisor straight away and barrier off the hazard.

Conclusion

A ladder is for getting up and down, or for short light jobs, and only when it is in good order and set up properly. If you are stretching, standing on the top rungs or the job needs both hands, stop and get the right access. If in doubt, ask your supervisor.

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Reference	NBF-TBT-004	Date	09.10.26
Topic	Ladders and General H&S		

By signing below I confirm I attended this toolbox talk, that I understood it, and that I had the chance to ask questions before signing.

Print Name	Signature	Date
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